

« BEFORE

Formerly an independent country, Vietnam was colonized by France in the 1880s. Resistance to this foreign domination was initially organized by Vietnam's traditional governing elite.

IMPERIAL DREAMS

The Vietnamese scholar-mandarins who resisted French colonialism—such as Phan Dinh Phung, who led a guerrilla movement in the 1890s, and Phan Boi Chau, a revolutionary in the early 20th century—envisaged a restoration of **imperial rule**.

However, the overthrow of the Qing Dynasty in China and its replacement by a republic in 1912 led many nationalists to abandon monarchism. The **Russian Revolution** of 1917 and the founding of the Moscow-based Communist International (Comintern) to encourage revolution worldwide brought a radical element to Vietnamese anticolonialism.



SOVIET PROPAGANDA

French authorities imposed severe restrictions on their Vietnamese subjects, denying them freedom of speech and the right to form political parties or trade unions. With little scope for political action, nationalists such as future South Vietnamese president Ngo Dinh Diem expressed their desire for independence through movements whose leaders were based abroad.

In the 1920s, Nguyen Thai Hoc founded the Vietnamese nationalist party Vietnam Quoc Dan Dang (VNQDD) in China. VNQDD was a republican movement modeled on China's own nationalist party, the Kuomintang. In February 1930, the VNQDD encouraged colonial army troops at Yen Bai, in northern Vietnam, to mutiny against their French officers. The mutiny came to nothing. French repression was swift, and Nguyen Thai Hoc was among the rebels executed.